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The Global Spanish Empire

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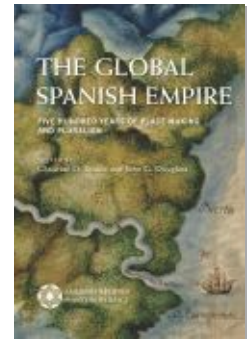
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Colonization, Transformations, and Indigenous Cultural Persistence in the Caribbean

Corinne L. Hofman, Roberto Valcárcel Rojas, and Jorge Ulloa Hung

The colonization of the Americas is one of the most transformative and notorious episodes in world history. The Caribbean was the initial space in the Americas the Spanish invaded and the first place where Amerindian-European-African intercultural dynamics played out (Map 2.1). The Caribbean, particularly Hispaniola, was where the Spanish experimented with strategies of conquest that would eventually be essential for expanding control into American continental mainland(s). The Caribbean was the port of entry to a universe of wealth that enabled the construction of the largest colonial empire of the sixteenth century. It was the key chapter of early modern Spanish colonialism (Montón-Subías et al. 2016), and as such it contributed to the establishment of Europe as the center of an increasingly connected global world (Beaule 2017). Yet while the indigenous Caribbean was at the center of the first contacts between Europe and the Americas, it eventually became largely invisible in colonial narratives. These narratives shifted to focus on conflict between colonial powers, the plantation universe, and the African slave trade (Valcárcel Rojas and Ulloa Hung 2018).

But there was more at play during this invasion than colonial narratives represent. With Christopher Columbus's landfall in 1492, the Spanish encountered a Caribbean islandscape with a plurality of island societies whose ancestors had migrated 8,000 to 6,000 years earlier from the South and possibly Central American coastal regions (Hofman et al. 2011; Keegan and Hofman 2017; Wilson 2007). The Spanish found a highly complex sociopolitical landscape with tendencies toward political centralization on Hispaniola and Puerto Rico. This area could be called a frontier or border. It was a space of interaction and confrontation between communities of the Greater and Lesser Antilles. At the time of European incursions, the Caribbean Sea was an arena of intricate networks



Map 2.1 Map of the Caribbean (by Corinne Hofman and Menno Hoogland).

echoing the overarching patterns of migration, mobility, and interaction among insular inhabitants and with individuals on the mainland (Hofman et al. 2014). These networks were flexible, robust, inclusive, and outward-looking systems that crossed local, regional, and pan-Caribbean boundaries (Hofman 2019; Hofman and Bright 2010; Hofman et al. 2011; Hofman et al. 2007; Hofman et al. 2014; Mol 2014; Oliver 2009). They comprised the movement of peoples and a diversity of elements, objects, ideas, and beliefs. However, the intention of these movements began to change, deliberately or through colonial action, under the newly imposed colonial sociopolitical regime. European colonizers used, manipulated, extended, changed, reinforced, interrupted, and incorporated these ancient networks for their own purposes (Amodio 1991; Hofman 2019; Hofman et al. 2014).

The first transfers of peoples, objects, and material goods between Amerindians and Europeans took place in an environment that united existing and preexisting natural and human-constructed landscapes. In essence, it reflected the construction of identities, scenarios, and places marked by plurality (Lightfoot et al. 1998), which it is essential to understand.

The neglect of the Caribbean region in historical narratives as the first port of entry to the Americas is to a great extent a direct consequence of

European colonial expansion to the mainland, the colonial quest for new resources, and the massive loss of indigenous life due to forced labor, slavery, imported diseases, and war (Valcárcel Rojas 2016b). The Caribbean islands provided testing grounds for Spanish domination and many of the economic, human, and logistic resources for the colonization of the mainland (Del Río Moreno 2012a, 2012b). Caribbean indigenous peoples participated in the colonization process as guides, translators, and laborers. They assumed multiple functions and identities in favor of the Spanish interests but also of their own living conditions and subsistence needs.

During the colonization of the islands and the continental expansion, the Antillean indigenous peoples were either no longer allowed to be “indigenous,” or, in some cases, they themselves wished to no longer be perceived as “indigenous” by the colonizers. They were generalized as *indio* or Carib and were assigned naturalized cultural features, such as a peaceful or violent attitude, that the Spanish used to justify their actions toward them: they were either evangelized (the friendly *indios*) as part of a civilizing action that included intensive labor exploitation, or they were enslaved (the warring and cannibal Carib) in order to take advantage of their forced labor. Generally, the Spanish rewrote the Greater Antilles as a home to the *indios*, both free and enslaved indigenous populations that formed a homogenized “Other” and negated their likely diverse original ethnic identities. The *indio*, diverse in their indigeneity but homogenized under the new social order, survived in many places across the region. They did so in reduced numbers, adapting to the norms of life of the colonial world and often mixing with other ethnicities: *indios* and mestizos were another colonial product squeezed from ancient Caribbean indigenous societies (Valcárcel Rojas 2016b; Valcárcel Rojas and Ulloa Hung 2018).

THE MULTIPLE SETTINGS OF EARLY EUROPEAN COLONIZATION OF THE CARIBBEAN

European settlement and colonization of the Caribbean were a series of processes within and between islands. The Spanish settled most of the areas around the Caribbean Sea during the sixteenth century, but their lack of interest and subsequent failed ventures at settlement in the Lesser Antilles left these islands to the Island Carib, or Kalinago, and thus outside of their control (Hofman 2019; Hofman et al. 2019; Wilson 2007).

The island of Saint Christopher was the first to be settled by the French and British in 1623–1625. Other islands in the Lesser Antilles, such as Dominica and Saint Vincent, remained beyond European domination until the 1800s.

Early on, due to poor resources, the Bahamas and part of the Lesser Antilles were regarded as labor suppliers and were considered *islas inútiles* (useless islands) by Royal Decree (Real Cédula 1503) (Deive 1995:90–91). Their populations were transported and put to work as slaves in the gold mines on Hispaniola, Cuba, and Puerto Rico, as well as in the pearl fisheries on Cubagua (Antczak et al. 2019; Hofman 2019; Valcárcel Rojas et al. 2019).

These differential timings of interest in particular areas of colonization were influenced and sometimes determined by European geopolitics, the flows of conquest and colonization toward North, Central, and South America, how indigenous populations responded to colonization, and the presence of exploitable resources on a particular island.

Using these varied colonial and indigenous histories as a background, in this chapter we focus on three scenarios that illustrate the transformations experienced by indigenous Caribbean communities in the early years of the European invasion of their territories. First, we will examine one of the most significant transformations. This occurred in the north of Hispaniola in the region where the first Spanish incursions into the interior of the American continent were made. There, diverse relations, interactions, and exchange of material culture occurred and were created between indigenous peoples, and Europeans began to transform the lives and worldview of native populations. It was during this initial period that the first Spanish forts were built and indigenous peoples, through either relocation by or flight from the Spanish, became increasingly mobile (Hofman et al. 2018).

The second important episode of indigenous transformation we explore is the massive translocation of indigenous communities across the Caribbean Sea as they increasingly became enslaved by the Spanish. The massive forced movement of indigenous peoples started with Columbus's second voyage and expanded during his third voyage. The initial exploitation of the gold mines in the center of Hispaniola, the construction of the settlement of Concepción de la Vega on that island, and later the exploitation of the pearl fisheries on the island of Cubagua, located off the coast of what is now Venezuela, motivated this transfer of indigenous

peoples as slaves, or *naborias*, across the Caribbean Sea (Hofman 2019; Valcárcel Rojas et al. 2019).

Third, we discuss the transformation experienced by indigenous peoples under new colonial conditions in the *encomienda* system (Arranz Márquez 1991; Deive 1995; Mira Caballos 2000; Valcárcel Rojas and Ulloa Hung 2018; Yeager 1995). The village and cemetery of El Chorro de Maíta, an early sixteenth-century *encomienda* in northeastern Cuba, illustrates this deeply destructive forced labor system and how the imposition of a Christian belief system changed daily life and transformed funeral practices and their associated material culture (Valcárcel Rojas 2016a). This case study and other Cuban archaeological contexts also show the adjustments and changes in the Spanish colonization strategy and in the processes of interaction with indigenous peoples.

To conclude, we present several cases that highlight the persistence of indigenous knowledge and practices in contemporary culture and daily life in Cuba and Hispaniola. These cases demonstrate that, despite colonial strategies to erase indigenous peoples and their culture, these strategies added a new dimension and sociohistorical significance to indigenous people in the structuring of the current local cultures of the Caribbean region (Hofman et al. 2018; Reyes Cardero 2018; Pesoutova 2019; Ulloa Hung and Valcárcel Rojas 2016; Valcárcel Rojas and Ulloa Hung 2018; Vega 1981).

FROM THE INDIGENOUS UNIVERSE TO A COLONIAL WORLD

According to European historic information, indigenous Hispaniola was divided into several *cacicazgos* (chiefdoms), whose number, structure, and extension have not yet been defined (Herrera Malatesta 2018; Oliver 2009; Vega 1990; Wilson 1990). *Cacicazgos* were likely a hierarchical sociopolitical organization headed by a number of leading individuals, or *caciques* (Redmond and Spencer 1994).

Northern Hispaniola was the first area in the Americas, following Columbus's landing on one of the Lucayan islands and his incursions into Cuba in 1492, where extensive interactions and confrontations between Amerindians and Europeans occurred (Hofman et al. 2018). It was from northern Hispaniola that the Spanish first entered the interior of the island in 1494, taking advantage of indigenous networks, knowledge, and,

likely, trails. It was in this area that the Spanish acquired new information about local food, the environment, and the functioning of indigenous societies that would be key to their expansion throughout the rest of the Antillean archipelago. Hispaniola is also where their political justification for subjugating indigenous peoples for labor and slavery emerged on their quest to conquer the American continent.

Following Columbus's second voyage, the Spanish promoted and intensified the exchange of goods with the interior of the island (Guerrero and Veloz Maggiolo 1988; Hofman et al. 2018; Keehnen 2019). Such exchanges helped the Spanish establish alliances with local caciques and gain information on the location of gold. These relationships simultaneously generated prestige for the indigenous communities, or at least the caciques with whom the Spanish were interacting. On April 9, 1494, Alonso de Ojeda illustrated the importance of these exchanges in the colonization of Hispaniola in the march to the fort of Santo Tomás, where he intended to learn about and "pacify" the island. In Ojeda's account of this event, Columbus referred to sending "bells and beads" in order to exchange them for supplies with indigenous peoples. They were also used to placate these groups, as well as obtain gold from them (Keehnen 2011). This practice was so important for colonial purposes that specific people were appointed to organize and supervise the exchanges (Romeu de Armas 1991:478).

For indigenous peoples this trade was sometimes a way not only to obtain exotic items and Spanish political support but also to increase their status among other indigenous groups in the region. More than 300 indigenous sites, ranging from the precolonial to early colonial period, were recently recorded in northern Hispaniola (Hofman et al. 2018). This represents only a small portion of the settlements that may have existed at the time of Spanish incursion because of the huge land transformations created by that process (Castilla-Beltrán et al. 2018; Hooghiemstra et al. 2018). Archaeological studies around the Ruta de Colón, the first colonial route running from the initial Spanish town of La Isabela on Hispaniola's north coast to the Cibao Valley, the "Valley of Gold" in the center of the island, show a landscape characterized by rockshelters or caves used as refuges or gathering places near the sea, as well as settlements in open spaces located on top of mountains and plateaus of important mountain systems, such as the Northern and Central Cordillera (Hofman et al. 2018; Ortega 1988; Ulloa Hung and Herrera Malatesta 2015).

Settlement patterns, the management of regional and local space, and the mixture of ceramic styles within the alluvial valleys of prominent rivers within the broader Cibao Valley suggest a far greater social and cultural diversity in the region at the time of contact than demonstrated by Spanish documents. These writings, often used to legitimize Spanish misbehavior and later reinforced by nineteenth-century anthropologists, reduced the peoples of Hispaniola and the Greater Antilles in general to a mere single Taíno culture (Curet 2014; Keegan and Hofman 2017).

Characteristic villages of northern Hispaniola had a pattern of mounds and earthworks surrounding leveled areas where houses were constructed (Hofman and Hoogland 2015; Hofman et al. 2018; Sonnemann et al. 2016; Ulloa Hung 2014; Veloz Maggiolo et al. 1981). The size and location of some of the villages suggest that they were important nodes in a social and political network that connected several landscapes and places. As such, the northern Hispaniola landscape appears to reflect an interactive environment that formed the basis for a Spanish route of colonial domination. The colonial narratives about the first expeditions into the interior of Hispaniola mention a system of social relations between indigenous communities that was widely exploited by the Spanish in their explorations from La Isabela to the Cibao Valley (León Guerrero 2000). The colonizers, led by indigenous guides, moved from one indigenous village to another (Las Casas 1875:29–30). These early contacts between vastly different worlds likely created a network of places that from then on were imbued with new meanings. These meanings would become part of the mechanisms of domination of other regions, locations, resources, and populations on Hispaniola. The imagined gold and richness of the indigenous landscape were constructed by colonial ambition, and it intercepted and mixed with the economic, social, and symbolic meanings attributed to these same places by indigenous peoples long before Spanish arrival. This created landscapes where meaning and place were variably assigned and created by different groups and where the meaning embedded in these places often clashed.

CHANGING MATERIAL CULTURAL REPERTOIRES

The exchange and intercultural dynamics in the early years of colonization created novel social identities and material cultural repertoires

(Deagan 2004; Hofman and Keehnen 2019; Hofman et al. 2018; Samson et al. 2016). Gold ornaments, foodstuffs, cotton, and exotic birds were reported to be the first items exchanged for European glass beads, bells, broken bowls, objects and fragments of metal, canvas shirts, and colored cloths (Keehnen 2011, 2019). European objects, which were present in very low quantities, have been recovered from indigenous sites, sometimes in clearly segregated areas with local paraphernalia, alluding to their integration into local assemblages as prestige items (Ernst and Hofman 2015; Keehnen 2011; Lopez Belando 2013; Samson 2010). Ethnohistoric information also suggests that these early exchanges comprised intangible features, such as names, that were key to the creation of alliances (Guaitiao status/friends) and provided critical information about resources, places, rivers, mountains, and the location of gold (Mira Caballos 2004).¹

The few European items found in Amerindian sites were apparently integrated and dispersed through the indigenous networks. Yet European pig and rat bones have also been found in fair amounts (Deagan 2004), probably indicating that some domesticates, particularly pig, were rapidly becoming part of local indigenous cuisine (Hofman et al. 2018; Van der Veen 2006). These European domesticates became an important economic and commercial medium that sustained part of the indigenous population in the later *encomiendas* during the period historians have called the “gold economy” (Del Río Moreno 1996, 2012a; Moya Pons 2016).² On the other hand, together with indigenous products, these European foods became the means of logistical support for the new expeditions to conquer other Caribbean islands and the adjacent American continent (Sued Badillo 2011).

THE FORGOTTEN ENSLAVED INDIGENOUS PEOPLE

During Columbus’s third and fourth voyages (1498 and 1502), the first expeditions to the Pearl Coast of northern Venezuela were made. In need of labor to exploit the gold mines on Hispaniola and the pearl fisheries on Cubagua, as well as making the slaves a commercial product in themselves, the Spanish began to enslave indigenous people in massive numbers across the Caribbean and neighboring mainland(s) (Valcárcel Rojas et al. 2019). This enslavement was regularly coupled with long-distance movement of enslaved individuals.

This enslavement of indigenous people augmented and became more visible with the increase of the gold economy under the government of Nicolás de Ovando on Hispaniola Island. After the royal decree of December 20, 1503, the distribution of enslaved *indios* was legalized. In that same year, the forced labor of indigenous peoples was also authorized, which encouraged the enslavement of indigenous people and the arming of expeditions to capture them. The Higüey Wars (1502–1503) were also linked to this episode and provided a large number of enslaved people for the mines and the movement of caciques from Higüey to Santo Domingo (Arranz Márquez 1991).

Portuguese slavery practices developed and implemented in the Iberian Peninsula and various kingdoms that would later form Spain (DeCorse 2001; Lobo Cabrera 1990) created experiences that influenced the new and early slave trade. These experiences would eventually result in capturing and selling indigenous people within the Caribbean and later exporting them to Europe. Other European powers would eventually repeat the same processes in their respective colonial spaces. In the circum-Caribbean area, from 1493 to 1552, between ca. 250,000 and 500,000 indigenous people were enslaved (Woodruff Stone 2014). It is argued that in the Western Hemisphere this slavery involved between two and five million victims (Bialuschewski and Fisher 2017). This practice preceded and influenced the one that would be established with Africans through the transatlantic trade (Anderson-Córdova 2017; Deive 1995; Sued Badillo 1995; Valcárcel Rojas 2016a; Valcárcel Rojas et al. 2019; Yaremko 2016).

Although there has been mention of the enslavement of Lucayan and Carib in historical documents, the slavery activities carried out by rich landowners, royal officials, shipowners, and entrepreneurs were not focused on a specific ethnic group or territory but included the Greater Antilles, the Bahamas, the Lesser Antilles, and much of Venezuela, Colombia, Central America, and New Spain. Enslaved indigenous people were often young, between 10 and 25 years old, although sometimes an entire population was captured, resulting in a wider age range. Groups of enslaved individuals could be from several towns of very different origin and cultures because of the variable nature of how and why the individuals were captured. The involuntary mobility of these populations and the process of enslavement also fundamentally forced the interaction of individuals from different places. In *estancias* (ranches), mines, or pearl

fisheries, free indigenous people lived with enslaved indigenous and African peoples of diverse origins. To a lesser extent they were servants in the Spanish houses, at least in the early days. It was a multicultural scenario marked by the demands that the colonial order imposed on each of these labor and social groups and in which each group had to take advantage of their previous acquired knowledge and that of others to find their own ways of survival (Altman 2013; Eugenio 2002; Valcárcel Rojas and Velázquez 2016). It is also in these spaces that the mestizos were born and many rebellions were generated. These multicultural spaces of enslaved and free folk not only brought wealth to the Spaniards but also grouped the constructed meanings of how the different colonized peoples handled and confronted their domination. These spaces laid the foundations for a process that created new social and cultural identities through the interaction of indigenous peoples with peoples from Africa and Europe.

GOLD, PEARLS, AND THE TRANSFORMATION OF SOCIAL AND CULTURAL IDENTITIES

The early centers of enslaved Amerindian labor were the Spanish towns of Nueva Cádiz de Cubagua, Venezuela, a hub of pearl extraction, and La Concepción de la Vega and Cotuí, in the Cibao Valley of Hispaniola, sites of the gold-mining industry (Antczak et al. 2019; Deive 1995; Olsen Bogaert et al. 2011). The architectural monumentality of La Vega and Nueva Cádiz demonstrates the economic power achieved in these settlements through the intensive exploitation of enslaved indigenous and African labor with a goal of organizing and intensifying mining work. This is particularly visible at Cotuí, one of the first goldmines exploited by the Spanish in Hispaniola (Olsen Bogaert et al. 2016). The mixed-material cultural repertoire and production techniques at these three sites reflect Amerindian, African, and Spanish intercultural dynamics (Antczak et al. 2019; Deagan 2004; Ernst and Hofman 2019; Ortega and Fondeur 1978; Ting et al. 2018), which are also recognizable in Puerto Real, in present-day Haiti (Deagan 1995).

Indigenous pottery continued to be produced, but in a simplified way. Vessel forms, decorative patterns, surface treatment, and vessel function changed considerably. For example, on Hispaniola the richly decorated indigenous vessels, adorned with elaborate anthropozoomorphic features,

were reduced to simple handles and knobs (Ernst and Hofman 2019; Hofman 2019). New vessel shapes influenced by indigenous Central or South American, African, and Spanish prototypes emerged (Figure 2.1; Ernst forthcoming; Ernst and Hofman 2019). Spanish vessel shapes were produced with local techniques, indicating the intention of maintaining the Iberian lifestyle in the colonies (Ernst and Hofman 2019; García Arévalo 1991; Ting et al. 2018). In addition to the traditional hand-built coiling techniques, the European potter's wheel was sometimes used.

THE ENCOMIENDA SYSTEM

The encomienda system is a prime example of the transformations happening during the early sixteenth century, when local Amerindian settlements were dominated by the Spanish and their populations were supplemented by nonlocal enslaved Amerindians and Africans. Under the control of the European colonizers, they were forced to accept Christian customs and traditions and provide labor for Spanish colonial enterprises (Hofman et al. 2014; Valcárcel Rojas 2016a; Valcárcel Rojas et al. 2013). With the encomienda system, Caribbean societies and cultures radically changed, yet indigenous peoples were able to (re)negotiate certain aspects of their precontact identities and material cultural practices (Hofman et al. 2014). This is one of the settings and one of the colonial structures where the *indio* began to emerge as a colonial category and identity (Valcárcel Rojas et al. 2014).

The ways in which the indigenous peoples acquired, used, and valued European materiality were extremely diverse throughout the Caribbean, and they depended on the place, time, and characteristics of their interaction with the Europeans (Beck et al. 2016; Gassón 1996; Smith 1988). Archaeological sites in Cuba show, with respect to Hispaniola, certain changes in how indigenous communities incorporated European materials. This seems to be typical of the Cuban case and perhaps of the other Antillean colonization processes (Jamaica, Puerto Rico) where the period of initial contact and negotiation, under indigenous autonomy, does not reach the extent and force seen in Hispaniola (Valcárcel Rojas 2016a, 2019).

In indigenous communities under the encomienda system, such as El Chorro de Maíta, El Porvenir, Barajagua, and Alcala, gift kit components (brass sheets, glass beads, or hawkbells) that were characteristic



Figure 2.1 Indigenous and transcultural ceramics from early colonial contexts at Cotuí and Concepción de la Vega (Dominican Republic) (identification by Marlieke Ernst in Ernst forthcoming; Ernst and Hofman 2019): (a, b) red slipped vessel necks with excised motifs from La Vega, probably Middle or South American indigenous influence; (c) shallow bowl with red, white, and black painting, probably Middle or South American indigenous influence; (d) indigenous (Chicoid) white clay effigy vessel; (e) vessel spout with zoomorphic modeled application; (f) sherd with incised decoration and quartz inlays, probably African influence; (g) sherd with comb-dragged decoration, probably African influence; (h) African olla with indigenous applications (knobs) from the mining camp of Cotuí. (Photos by Jorge Ulloa Hung, Corinne Hofman, and Menno Hoogland.)

of the act of *rescate* (trade) at the beginning of the Spanish invasion decreased, and tools and weapons became more common (Valárcel Rojas 2019). The fact that the historical and ethnohistorical data of the Greater Antilles do not mention weapons and tools as a typical part of the artifacts for trade or gift or that the *rescate* was developed in negotiation contexts that were more common in Hispaniola than in the other islands suggests a change in the strategies of interaction and transfer of objects. This reveals a process where trade lost relevance and European objects, as referred to in certain historical sources (Marte 1981:115–120), were instead given as payment for work or services provided. At the same time, the *encomienda* system changed the indigenous perspective of the Spaniards and their material culture. Indigenous groups were now more geared to take advantage of Spanish technology and other resources rather than to value the exoticism of Spanish materiality (Figure 2.2; Valcárcel Rojas 2019).

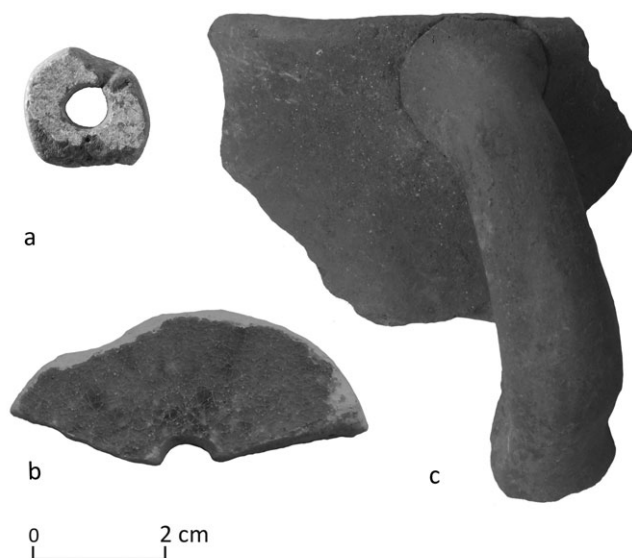


Figure 2.2 Intercultural early colonial ceramic assemblages from El Chorro de Maíta (Cuba): (a, b) modified European ceramic sherds; (c) copy of a Spanish vessel using coiling technique, El Chorro de Maíta, Cuba. (Photos by Roberto Valcárcel Rojas.)

CHANGING ATTITUDES TOWARD THE COLONIZER: TRANSFORMATIONS OF IDENTITY AND PERSISTENCE OF CULTURAL PRACTICES

El Chorro de Maíta was an indigenous village in the northeast of Cuba under colonial control in the early sixteenth century. Details on the demography and cultural behavior of the population considered to be native to the region near the site, as well as historical data on encomiendas in this part of northeastern Cuba, allow us to confirm that the indigenous population of El Chorro de Maíta lived under the encomienda system (Valcárcel Rojas 2016a). Although European objects and food such as pork (Pérez Iglesias and Valcárcel Rojas 2014) were incorporated into the life of the community, the funerary context, with more than 130 inhumed individuals, provides the greatest evidence of change. Amerindians, an individual of African descent, possible mestizos, and one immigrant from the Yucatán peninsula were buried in a confined space in the center of the village (Laffoon 2012; Valcárcel Rojas 2016a; Valcárcel Rojas et al. 2011; Weston and Valcárcel Rojas 2016). The demographic profile of the population and the structure of the cemetery indicate that infectious diseases, possibly associated with European contact, affected the El Chorro population and caused an increase in mortality (Weston and Valcárcel Rojas 2016). A decline in cranial modification was noted in the non-adult individuals, likely reflecting significant changes in indigenous identity in the early colonial period as well (Duijvenbode 2017; Valcárcel Rojas 2016a; Weston and Valcárcel Rojas 2016). The mortuary practices revealed a mix of Amerindian and European burial traditions; the flexed burials typical of precolonial practices were mixed with the European way of burying the deceased in a stretched position with the arms crossing the chest, as the Christian belief system demanded (Valcárcel Rojas 2016a). The latter practice is found in nearly 10 percent of the buried individuals, including those of indigenous origin.

European brass aglets were found with several burials, indicating, along with certain taphonomic evidence, that deceased individuals were probably dressed in European clothing. For example, in one burial a fragment of European linen was found. Other individuals were interred with a mix of *guanín* (gold and copper alloy), gold ornaments from Colombia, and European brass items. Archaeometric analysis and (ethno)historical

information suggest that the indigenous peoples received all these objects from the Spanish (Martín Torres et al. 2012; Valcárcel Rojas 2016a; Valcárcel Rojas and Martín-Torres 2013).

There were precolonial indigenous identities, as well as identities built by the adjustment to the colonial environment, like the *indios* (people who abandon or are forced to abandon their symbols of identity and develop ways of life of colonial character) in El Chorro de Maíta. There were also other identities gestated from ethnic and cultural mix (*mezizos*). This is the result of a process of ethnogenesis from which new human and cultural products emerge. Some of these individuals can be considered criollos (people of Spanish descent born in the Americas) by their local birth (Valcárcel Rojas et al. 2014). It is a scenario where diverse cultural traditions interacted and coexisted. At El Chorro de Maíta, there is an ethnic intermingling that likely foreshadows a future Cuban identity. This complex mixture denies the idea of an immediate and total collapse of the indigenous world and reveals continuity beyond the moments of conquest. It reveals the indigenous and *indios* as protagonists with strength and a capacity for resistance and adjustment that traditional historiography does not perceive (Sued Badillo 1992; Valcárcel Rojas and Ulloa Hung 2018). Here, identities coexisted (indigenous, *indios*, Africans, *encomendados*, and slaves) and new identities were created, imposing a plurality that, despite being marked by domination, brought different meanings together to the place where these forgotten actors lived or died.

PERSISTENCE AND CONTINUITY IN THE CONTEMPORARY CARIBBEAN

The substitution, displacement, and/or disappearance of indigenous cultural traditions, knowledge, and peoples as suggested by traditional historical narratives (Córdova 1968; Mira Caballos 2009; Moya Pons and Flores Paz 2013) are strongly countered by their presence in modern Caribbean society. Here, persistence, understood through its multiple connotations (Panich 2013), is regarded as a phenomenon that is largely hidden by miscegenation and by the way in which the indigenous legacy was connected to or was superimposed by other cultural traditions (Pesoutova 2019; Ulloa Hung and Valcárcel Rojas 2016; Valcárcel Rojas and Ulloa Hung 2018). The ways in which colonial identities were organized

and recorded in different parts of the Americas (Reyes Cardero 2018), including in the Caribbean, served to modify and hide the presence of indigenous peoples and eventually their descendants.

As part of these processes, it is possible to observe a constant formation and superposition of identities that was generated not only by colonial domination but also by indigenous resistance and adaptation. This phenomenon occurred in spaces rearranged and transformed by the Europeans, who fostered both urban and rural population centers, as well as multiple spaces of economic exploitation. The indigenous peoples participated not only in the construction of those places loaded with European colonial meanings but also in their effort to adjust and survive. It is necessary to take into consideration the indigenous nature of the many places of resettlement, refuge, and resistance where the indigenous peoples and their descendants connected their natural and symbolic environment with the new universe created and, eventually, controlled by the Europeans.

Indigenous features persist in the spiritual and material culture of the Caribbean and constitute an important part of everyday life. These elements are evident in the Dominican Republic and Cuba, where the physical presence of indigenous descendants is still maintained (Barreiro and Hartman 2018). The indigenous legacy is visible in toponyms, cuisine, crops, storage artifacts, kitchen and labor utensils, the extensive use of forms of traditional agriculture (slash-and-burn, *conucos*), house building, an array of cultural traditions, stories, and ritual practices, as well as in the intensive use of indigenous plant species for economic and curative purposes (Figure 2.3).

For example, in Cuba and the Dominican Republic the use of native materials combined with the way houses are constructed, the decisions to settle at particular elevations, good visibility, good access to fresh water sources, and protection from floods are important elements of contemporary settlement activity. Sometimes, places formerly inhabited and used by indigenous peoples are reused, and some of the precolonial techniques aimed at landscape transformation continue into the present. The production of ceramics by indigenous peoples in colonial contexts during the sixteenth century resulted in a ceramic tradition that was observed in Cuba until the eighteenth century and in the Dominican Republic until the present.



Figure 2.3 Examples of the persistence of indigenous cultural traditions recorded in Cuba and the Dominican Republic: (a) a house built with traditional techniques and materials, Amina, Dominican Republic; (b) a potter in Higüerito, Dominican Republic; (c) a sieve made of vegetable fibers used in the production of cassava, Fray Benito, Holguín, Cuba; (d) gold washing in San José de las Matas, Dominican Republic. (Photos by Jorge Ulloa Hung and Roberto Valcárcel Rojas.)

All of these aspects constitute an important part of everyday life in the Caribbean today, and this persistence of indigenous ways of doing and being is most visible in a sense of belonging and human resilience and persistence, as well as in the genetic composition of the contemporary populations (García Molina et al. 2007; Hofman et al. 2018; Martínez-Cruzado et al. 2001; Pesoutova and Hofman 2016; Rodríguez Ramos and Pagán-Jiménez 2016; Schroeder et al. 2018; Ulloa Hung 2005; Ulloa Hung and Valcárcel Rojas 2016; Valcárcel Rojas and Ulloa Hung 2018;

Vega 1981). This is of great importance in various aspects of the rural and urban world of these countries and demonstrates the various ways in which this legacy survived and is inserted into the new material universe (Ulloa Hung 2018; Valcárcel Rojas 2016b; Valcárcel Rojas et al. 2018).

In Hispaniola, the indigenous cultural legacies were also picked up by black and free mulattoes within a larger economy of cattle ranches and subsistence or domestic agriculture developed in an environment of rurality and isolation on the periphery of a large colonial village (González 2011). For years this population maintained traditional forms of cultivation and food habits and part of the material culture originating in and transformed from precolonial indigenous cultures. In the rural portions of the island, the use of hammocks, cassava, and *conucos* (small plots for cultivation), the manufacture of pottery, and a wide variety of objects made of wood that include canoes and *santos de palo* (images of Christian saints carved in wood) were kept as important elements. *Macutos*, *cerones*, *arganas* (containers made of vegetable fibers), trays, and wooden rafts, among other things, are the basis of the rich utilitarian artisanal variety that still exists to this day (De La Cruz and Durán Núñez 2012).

CONCLUSIONS

Our research reveals a complex and diverse Caribbean sociocultural landscape on the eve of the colonial incursions. The enmeshed spheres and lines of social interaction among the indigenous communities, from precolonial moments onward, cemented a regional history marked by coexistence, interaction, and transculturation. Social networks were shaped by expanding and contracting group territories, fission and fusion of local communities, variable degrees of sociopolitical integration, and differential responses to colonization, all of which were fundamental in the formation of the modern globalized society both in the Caribbean and across the world.

The cases presented in this chapter show the variability and multiple outcomes of a universe of intercultural dynamics and contacts that is still not fully recognized or even understood today. In many ways, these contest the historical data that regularly exclude the indigenous voice and their living and working contexts. Archaeological research and discussions with contemporary island inhabitants enable us to uncover some

of these subaltern strata. Archaeological data combined with historical information also show us the plurality of identities that have emerged in the colonial universe and the way they have unfolded in the most diverse spaces and places, constructing and transforming them. The ability to reach the present or provide a legacy that reaches us is a key aspect of the cultural and human nature of this region.

From the resistance and persistence of the indigenous people within their relationship to Europeans and Africans, a diverse mestizo Caribbean was born. This emergence cannot be separated from the precolonial world. This Caribbean is marked by colonial action and the destruction of indigenous societies, but it is also marked by the ability of these individuals to survive and to find ways to connect with other ethnic and cultural groups. Recovering the history of the construction of a multi-ethnic and multicultural Caribbean, in which the indigenous peoples are protagonists, can help overcome the Eurocentric vision that imposes a homogeneous history and a future without space for anything that is non-Western. It also connects us with a history that from its beginning is much more diverse and complex than that offered by traditional narratives based on early colonial documents.

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NOTES

1. Guaitiao was the traditional pact of brotherhood or friendship that was made between the indigenous chiefs and that could include the exchange of names, gifts, and wives. After the arrival of the Europeans, it was used to formalize the alliances of the indigenous leaders with the Europeans.

2. The period between 1502 and 1510 on Hispaniola is known as the gold economy. This was the height of gold extraction on the island using indigenous labor through the *encomienda* system and slavery. During that period, cattle husbandry and other activities constituted a complementary economy to mining extraction.

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